

Facilitator Guide

For facilitators running the Cowork build-along. Cowork is task-shaped, not agent-shaped: participants give Copilot a job, set a schedule, and let it use their full M365 — Outlook, Teams, Calendar, SharePoint, Power BI.

Session at a glance

Tier	Microsoft Copilot Cowork — scheduled tasks across M365
Session length	75 minutes (45 build, 20 explore, 10 Q&A)
Audience	Operators, managers, ICs who already use M365 Copilot day to day
Group size	Webinar — no participant cap; chat moderation recommended
Format	Webinar build-along — each participant configures one recurring Cowork task live on the call
Deliverable	A scheduled Cowork task that runs without further user input

What this session unlocks

This is the 'AI teammate' moment. Up to here, Copilot has been reactive — you ask, it answers. Cowork is the first time it does work while you sleep, using YOUR mail, YOUR calendar, YOUR Power BI. Participants leave with something on the calendar Monday morning.

Prerequisites — confirm before the session

- Cowork mode enabled on each participant's Copilot tenant
- Each participant signed into M365 Copilot with their work account
- Each participant has at least one Power BI report they can read (for the BI-based tasks)
- Each participant has Outlook, Teams, and Calendar access on the same account
- You have personally run each of the six Cowork tasks in your own tenant
- A 'do not auto-post' default is briefed up-front and reinforced every step

Materials checklist

- The six Cowork build-along PDFs (one per function)
- A printed cheat-sheet listing the six tasks
- This facilitator guide and a visible timer
- A backup tenant where you've pre-configured each of the six tasks

Success criteria

- Every participant has saved a scheduled Cowork task
- Every participant has run their task ONCE manually and reviewed the output
- Every task starts with 'Do NOT send/post automatically — leave the draft for me to review.'
- Participants can name the M365 surfaces Cowork touched for them: mail, Teams, calendar, Power BI, files

Agenda & Timing

Block-by-block plan. Run the clock visibly — participants build faster when they can see the pace.

Time	Block	Talk track / Action
00:00 - 05:00	Open & frame	Recap the four tiers. Today Copilot stops being a chatbot and becomes a scheduled teammate.
05:00 - 15:00	Open Cowork & pick task	Each participant opens Cowork mode and picks one of six tasks. Confirm surfaces available.
15:00 - 30:00	Paste headline task	Paste the prompt from the PDF. Walk the structure: numbered steps, do-not-post rule.
30:00 - 40:00	Configure schedule	Set frequency and time. Choose Inline execution mode (context across runs).
40:00 - 55:00	Run once now & verify	Run manually before scheduling kicks in. Use the verification checklist.
55:00 - 65:00	Try a 'Live' variant	Use the 'Try These Live' page — a one-shot job instead of a scheduled one.
65:00 - 75:00	Q&A and 'where next'	Address governance, security, scheduling pitfalls, and the 'humans-stay-in-loop' rule.

Pacing tip

The headline task is long — five or six numbered steps. Participants will want to type it. Don't let them. Copy-paste from the PDF, then adapt names/channels. The lesson is that Cowork prompts are SPECIFICATIONS, not casual requests.

Facilitator Notes — Step by Step

What to say, what to do, and what to watch for at each build step.

1 Open Cowork mode

Say: Cowork lives in M365 Copilot — left rail, second mode. It has access to YOUR M365.

Do: Each participant opens Cowork. Confirm the surfaces panel lists Outlook, Teams, Calendar, SharePoint, Power BI.

Watch for: Some tenants need Cowork toggled on by an admin. Confirm before the session — not during.

2 Paste the headline task

Say: This isn't a chat prompt — it's a small spec. Numbered steps, one job per step, a do-not-auto-post line.

Do: Open a new Cowork task. Paste the prompt verbatim from the PDF.

Watch for: Long prompts can drop blank lines from PDF copy. Tell them blank lines are decorative — content is what matters.

3 Adapt names, channels, reports

Say: The PDF uses sample names. Replace with your real channel, your real Power BI report.

Do: Watch the chat pane. Coach each participant to point the task at THEIR data, not the sample.

Watch for: Don't let them skip this. A task pointed at a sample report won't ever do real work.

Facilitator Notes — Continued

Final build steps, common blockers, and how to keep the room engaged.

4 Set the schedule

Say: Pick the time that lands BEFORE you need it. Friday 5pm for Monday prep. 7am for the standup.

Do: Schedule pane → frequency, time, Inline mode. Inline so context persists across runs.

Watch for: Inline vs Separate confuses people. Default Inline — explain Separate only if asked.

5 Run once now & verify

Say: Don't trust a recurring task you haven't run manually first. Run it now. Review.

Do: Hit Run now. Wait. Use the verification checklist on page 1 of the build-along PDF.

Watch for: Be ready to tighten the prompt if the first run misses something. That's the learning.

6 Confirm draft-only on writes

Say: Every email, every Teams post — left as a draft. Humans send. Cowork prepares.

Do: Open Outlook drafts and Teams drafts after the run. Show the drafts waiting.

Watch for: Reinforce this clearly on the call. The single most important habit on this tier.

Engagement prompts (use when energy drops)

- Whose first run found something they didn't know about their inbox / calendar / Power BI report?
- Who has a task they want Cowork to do every Monday at 7am that nobody else needs to know about?
- What would change about your Friday afternoon if you could trust this task?
- What would you NEVER let Cowork send for you automatically — and why?

Common Blockers & Q&A Bank

The questions you will be asked. Have these crisp.

Common blockers (and your fix)

- **Cowork mode not visible in left rail**

→ Tenant hasn't enabled Cowork. Note the tenant ID, follow up with admin. Continue with reference demo.

- **Task can't see Power BI**

→ User has no Power BI license or the report isn't shared with them. Use a different example.

- **Scheduled run never fires**

→ Time zone confusion — confirm GMT vs local. Re-save the schedule with explicit time.

- **Output goes to the wrong Teams channel**

→ Channel name disambiguation. Use the channel ID from Teams → ... → Get link, not the display name.

- **Task ran but the draft is missing**

→ Look in BOTH Outlook drafts and Teams drafts. Cowork puts each in its native draft area.

- **Auto-posted instead of drafted**

→ Prompt missing the 'Do NOT post automatically — leave the draft' line. Add it. Re-run.

Top participant questions

Q: Is Cowork an agent?

A: Conceptually, yes — but architecturally it's a scheduled TASK with full M365 access, not a topic-and-tool agent like Studio. Different shape, different use cases.

Q: Does Cowork see things I can't see?

A: No. It acts AS YOU — same mail, same Teams, same files, same Power BI access you have. Nothing more, nothing less.

Q: What if it sends something embarrassing?

A: Default rule: 'Do NOT send/post automatically — leave the draft for me to review.'
Every Cowork prompt in this pack opens with that line. Reinforce it every time.

Q: How is this different from Studio?

A: Studio agents answer when called. Cowork tasks work on a schedule and act across your full M365. Use Studio for shared, governed actions; Cowork for personal recurring work.

Q: Can I share a Cowork task with my team?

A: Cowork tasks are personal — they run as the owner. For shared, scheduled workflows, look at Studio with Power Automate.

Top participant questions — continued

Q: What happens when I'm on vacation?

A: Task continues running unless paused. Pause it before you go if you don't want drafts piling up — or repoint the task to send the digest to your delegate.

Q: Can it call Power BI semantic models directly?

A: Yes — it can read reports and semantic models you have access to. Be specific: name the report or model in the prompt.

Tier Comparison & Per-Function Reference

Use this to answer 'why this tier, not another?' and to tailor language by function.

When to use which Copilot tier

Tier	Best for	Time to value	Governance
Free Copilot Chat	Pure-instruction agents anyone can build, no data upload	5 minutes	Tenant policies apply; no extra data residency to consider
Paid M365 Copilot	Add your own knowledge (Excel, docs) for grounded answers	15 minutes	Stays inside the tenant; admin governs sharing
Copilot Studio	Full agents with topics, tools, orchestration, evaluations, channels	Hours to days	Solution-managed; DLP, RLS, Entra auth, audit trail
Copilot Cowork	Task-driven recurring work using your live M365 surfaces	10 minutes	Acts as the signed-in user; consent and review-before-send patterns

Per-function quick reference

HR — HR Pulse (Monday 7:30am)

FOCUS

Inbox triage + requisition counts + draft for HR leadership Teams channel.

WATCH FOR

Reinforce draft-only on the Teams post — never auto-post leadership messages.

IT — IT Channel Triage (9am daily)

FOCUS

Group tickets, find recurring questions, draft replies, post triage to leadership.

WATCH FOR

Recurring-question detection needs 30 days of history — set expectations.

Sales — Pipeline Prep (Friday 5pm)

FOCUS

Per-meeting briefs from email, Teams, and Power BI pipeline.

WATCH FOR

Validate the right Power BI report is named — sellers have many.

Finance — Month-End Variance (1st working day)

FOCUS

Power BI variances → Excel pack → draft owner outreach.

WATCH FOR

Audit trail is critical — cite Power BI visual + Excel cell for every number.

CS — Overnight Escalation Digest (8am)

FOCUS

Mail + Teams + Power BI escalations deduplicated and ranked.

WATCH FOR

Dedup logic is fragile — verify on the first run.

Marketing — Campaign Read-Out (Monday 7am)

FOCUS

Power BI ROI + at-risk flag + draft leadership update.

WATCH FOR

Marketing data shifts weekly — flag 'unusual movement' >25%.

Closing

Not a chatbot. A scheduled teammate with full access to your M365.

Closing talk track

Recap the journey: free chat → grounded data → Studio agents → Cowork tasks. Four shapes, one ladder.

Homework: pick ONE recurring thing they do every week and write a Cowork task for it before Friday.

Reinforce one last time: 'Do NOT send/post automatically — leave the draft for me to review.' Always. Until trust is earned.